

JUDITH

THE BOOK OF JUDITH.

PREFACE.

The sacred writer of this Book is generally believed to be the high priest Eliachim, (called also Joachim.) The transactions herein related, most probably happened in his days, and in the reign of Manasses, after his repentance and return from captivity. It takes its name from that illustrious woman, by whose virtue and fortitude, armed with prayer, the children of Israel were preserved from the destruction threatened them by Holofernes and his great army. It finishes with her canticle of thanksgiving to God. Ch. --- He was a chief officer at court, under Ezechias, (4 K.

xviii. 18. H.) before he was high priest, assuming his father Helchias's name.

Many suppose that he was the author of this Book, as Josephus informs us that the priests recorded the most remarkable transactions. But this would prove that they wrote all the histories of the Bible. S.

Jerom (in Agg. i. 6.) seems to believe that Judith left these memoirs. Yet we have no certain proof of the author. Josephus passes over this history, as he professed to exhibit only the Heb.

books. Ant. x. 11. Prol. &c. S. Jerom doubts not but this was written in Chaldee, from which language he translated it; unless he caused it to be first explained to him in Heb. as he did the Book of Tobias. C. --- He might, however, have attained sufficient knowledge of the former language, which is so like the Hebrew, before he undertook this work. H. --- He professes to give

"the sense," rather than a verbal translation. The Greek must have been taken from another copy, and is followed by the Syriac, in which we find some passages more exact than in the present Greek copies. The original is entirely lost. It might have removed many difficulties. Those however which are started by our adversaries, are not unanswerable. Grotius would suppose that this work is only a parable,

representing the state of the Jewish church under the persecution of Epiphanes. But this singular notion has no foundation; and if it had, the authenticity of the Book would not be endangered, as the parable both of the Old and New Testament are certainly true, and written by inspiration. C. --- Luther styles it a poetical comedy; (Pref. et Sympos. 29.) but both Jews and Christians have esteemed it as a true history: (W.) and this innovator (H.) allows, that "the Book is beautiful, and written by an inspired prophet." C. --- The Fathers have looked upon it with the utmost veneration; and S. Jerom, though he was at one time under some doubts, placed it on a level with the Books of Ruth, and Esther, &c. Ep. ad Principiam. --- It is admitted by Origen, Tertullian, S. Chrys. S. Hilary, V. Bede, &c. as the history of a most valiant matron, delivering God's people from a cruel tyrant. W. --- Some place this event under Cambyzes, son of Cyrus; (Euseb. S. Aug.) others under Xerxes, (Torniel) or Darius Hystaspes, (E.) or Ochus: (Sulp. Severus) but the opinion which has been given above is more accurate; (C.) or rather Bethulia was saved, while Manasses was in captivity, (in the 10th year of his reign) and the high priest administered affairs in his absence. At this point, Judith might be thirty-five years old. She lived seventy years afterwards; and many days (perhaps eight years more) passed before the country was invaded by Pharaoh Nechao. C. xvi. 30. Thus Manasses survived 45 years, Amon 2, Josias 31; total 78. This chronology removes every difficulty. Houbig. Pref. --- If true, it seems probable that the work would be originally in Heb. as the Chaldee was used only after the captivity, (H.) which may be farther proved from C. i. 15. Greek.

Houbigant. --- Protestants prefer to translate this and the other apocrypha from the Greek. M.

JUDITH 1

CHAPTER I.

Ver. 1. Now, refers to the internal purpose of the author. S. Greg. hom 2. in Ezec. W. Many of the books begin with And; shewing their connection. This work formed a part of the general history. The building of Ecbatana likewise took place soon after the destruction of Ninive, mentioned in the preceding book. --- Arphaxad. He was probably the same as is called Dejoces by Herodotus; to whom he attributes the building of Ecbatana, the capital city of Media; (Ch.) or Arphaxad, more resembles both in name and actions the second king Phraortes or Apharaartas, (Montfaucon and Houbig.) who fortified and embellished the city. C. --- Ecbatana, or Agbata, which in Arabic signifies

"variegated;" (Bochart) as the seven walls, rising one higher than another round it, were marked with one white, two black, three red, four blue, five dark red, six silver, seven gold. Herod. i. 98. C. See Tob. iii. 7.

Ver. 2. Hewed. Gr. adds, "three cubits broad and six long." The ancients aimed at solidity in their architecture, as appears from their ruins. C. --- High. Salien (A. 3345) thinks there is a transposition, and that the walls were 70 cubits high.

M. --- What need was there of such a breadth? Gr. allows 70 in height, and 50 in breadth, which seems more proportionate. Old Vulg.

has 60 cubits high, and 50 broad. On the walls of Ninive, three chariots might fight abreast, (C.) and six on those of Babylon. Ctesias. --- Feet. Projecting from the wall, to remove an enemy.

M. --- Gr. "and the towers thereof he placed above the gates 100 cubits, and the foundation was 60 cubits broad. And he made the gates to rise 70 cubits, being 40 cubits in breadth, to send out the armies of his mighty men, and to draw up his infantry." H.

Ver. 4. Gloried. Fool, this night wilt thou perish. Luke xii. 20. W.

Ver. 5. Nabuchodonosor. Not the king of Babylon, who took and destroyed Jerusalem, but another of the same name, who reigned in Nivine; and is called by profane historians Saosduchin.

He succeeded Asarhaddon in the kingdom of the Assyrians, and was contemporary with Manasses, king of Juda. Ch. --- He might be the same with Asarhaddon, who resided at Ninive in the 20th year of his reign. After the defeat at Bethulia, the Medes recovered part of their power, under Cyaxares I.

who was succeeded by Astyages and Cyaxares II. with whom Cyrus was associated in the empire. Xenophon. --- Asarhaddon spent the latter years of his life at Babylon, of which he had made himself master. Houbigant. --- The Jews frequently give names to foreign princes different from those by which they are known in profane history. See Tob. ult. H. ---

Him. Gr. afterwards (v. 15) insinuates, that he prevented any from mounting the throne of Media, till this work was written, "he transfixed him with his darts, and destroyed him till this day."

Houbigant.

Ver. 6. Ragau, near Rages. Tob. i. 16. M. --- Syr. "Dura," mentioned Dan. iii. 1. C.

--- Jadason, or Mount Jason, above the Caspian gates; (Strabo xi.) unless it may be the city Jassu, in Armenia.

Gr. has "the Hydaspes," a river of India, though Curtius (v.) places it near Susa; confounding it with the Choaspes. --- Elicians. Gr. "Elymeans," perhaps the same with Pontus. Heb. Ellasar.

Gen. xiv. 9. Various battles were fought during this war, which the Greek intimates lasted seven years. C. --- That version also would represent those and various other nations coming to meet Nabuchodonosor, who hereupon sent his ambassadors to all in Persia, and westward to Cilicia,

&c. As they were treated contemptuously, he swore that he would revenge himself. But first he attacked Arphaxad, took and sacked Ninive, slew the king, and then abandoned himself with his army to pleasure in the conquered city,

"120 days." H.

Ver. 8. Esdreton. Syr. "Jezrael," which is the usual name in Scripture. Jos. xvii.

16.

Ver. 9. Jesse, or Gessen, where Joseph placed his brethren. Gen. xlv. 34.

Ver. 11. Refused. Gr. adds, "and did not come to help him in the war, because they feared him not, (H. supposing he would have enough to do with Arphaxad) as he was but like their equal, or as one man. C.

Ver. 12. Countries. Those who were subject to him did wrong in refusing aid.

But the Jews were under no such obligations; and God espoused their cause the more, as the king set up for a deity. C. iii. C. --- He had at first entertained thoughts of universal dominion, (H.) being elated by his victory, like other conquerors. --- *Auferre, trucidare, rapere falsis nominibus imperium, atque ubi solitudinem faciunt, pacem appellant.* Tacit. Agric.

JUDITH 2

CHAPTER II.

Ver. 1. Thirteenth. Gr. 18th. --- Month. Nisan, in spring.

Ver. 2. Secret. Lit. "mystery." Tob. xii. 7. C. --- Abditos principis sensus exquirere illicitum.

Tacit. An. vi.

Ver. 3. Empire. "The thirst of empire and riches is an old and deep-rooted cause of making war."

Sallust. Frag. --- Gr. adds, "and they (counsellors) judged that all flesh must be destroyed of those who had not complied with his order." H. --- God laughs at the vain designs of men. C.

Ver. 4. Armies. Gr. adds, "and the second after himself," in the kingdom. M. ---

Casaubon suspects that this drunkard was the king mentioned in history, as having lost the kingdom of Cappadocia, by attempting to introduce the dissolute feasts of Baccus. Polyb. xxxii. ap. Athen. x.

11. --- He made his attack first upon this country, v. 13.

Ver. 5. Commandment. Gr. adds, he must demand "earth and water," as an acknowledgment of his dominion, and that all necessities of life belonged to him. This custom prevailed in Persia.

Herod. iv. 123. Polyb. xix. Brisson iii.

Ver. 9. Syria: part of which, it seems, had submitted. C. --- Gr. "and corn for every man, in abundance," (H.) for fear it should be carried off in the countries which he invaded. M.

Ver. 11. Archers. Gr. adds, "a mixed multitude," not bearing arms. Ex. xii. 38.

Ver. 12. When. Gr. "and they proceeded from Ninive, three days' journey, to the plain of Bektileth," or Bagdania, in Cappadocia, between Mount Argee and Taurus. Strabo (xii.) assures us that Argee is the highest mountain in the country, from which the two seas of Cilicia and the Euxine may be seen. C.

Ver. 13. Melothus, or Melita, built by Semiramis, (Pliny vi. 3.) in the same country. --- Tharsis, or Cilicia, peopled by the son of Javan. --- Ishmahel, on the Euphrates, east of the Desert Arabia.

Ver. 14. Mambre. Gr. "Abrona, (C.) or Arbonai;" (H.) that is, from the river Chaboras to the Persian Gulph, or sea. C.

Ver. 15. Japheth, or Joppe, now Jaffa. Serarius. --- Gr. "he cut in pieces all who opposed him; and he came to the borders of Japheth, which are on the south, over-against Arabia."

Ver. 16. Carried. Greek, "surrounded...and burnt their tents, and plundered their folds for cattle:" mandras. H. --- Madian lay to the east of the Dead Sea. C.

Ver. 17. Harvest. The rapidity of his conquests was astonishing, as all this had been done in six or seven weeks, v. 1. But Holofernes probably sent his lieutenants into different parts at the same time. C. --- Caused. Gr. "he burnt all their fields, and destroyed their flocks and herds, and plundered their cities, and put to the sword all their young men."

Ver. 18. Land. Gr. adds, "on the sea-shore, in Sidon,...Ascalon," &c. H.

JUDITH 3

CHAPTER III.

Ver. 1. Kings. Gr. "they sent to him ambassadors, with proposals for peace, saying: Behold we, the servants of Nabuchodonosor, the great king, lay before thee; use us as thou thinkest best," &c.

These proposals were made by those on the sea-coast, from Sidon and Tyre to Ascalon, from whom Holofernes took "the choicest men," being received with honour, v. 10. H. --- Syria, &c.

These are not specified in the Greek. --- Sobal, or Soba, (1 K. xiv. 47.) near Damascus, where Ptolemy (v.) places Samoulis. --- Lybia seems too remote, and had not been attacked: some therefore would read Lycia, or Lygia, (Herod.

vii. 72.) or rather Lydia, (C.) which Holofernes had

"cut in pieces," according to the Greek. C. ii. 13. H.

Ver. 2. Great. This was his usual title. Dan. ii. 30. 4 K. xviii. 19. C. --- Slavery. Yet they make an unconditional submission. H. --- It is better for us to submit to servitude than to be slaughtered like our brethren. M.

Ver. 3. Sight, at thy disposal. Gen. xiii. 9. Prov. xv. 11.

Ver. 10. Lights. Torches were used to testify joy. 2 Mac. iv. 22.

Ver. 11. Though. Greek, "He demolished all their borders, and cut down their groves."

Ver. 13. Called. Gr. "Worshipped by all nations, and that all their tongues and tribes might call him god." H. --- Behold to what lengths ambition may be carried. If he had only claimed a place among the other pagan deities, his title was as good as theirs. C. --- He is a figure of Antichrist; for whom all heretics pave the way. 2 Thes. ii. W.

Ver. 14. Apamea, on the river Orontes, between which and the river Eleutherus, lay the Mesopotamia here mentioned. --- Idumeans, or to "Rama," near Gabaa, which was on the north of Jerusalem; whereas Idumea lay far to the south. C.

--- Yet (H.) Gabaa may designate a mountainous country, as 1 K. vii. 1. (M.) and there is no reason why Idumea might not have felt the power of Holofernes, as well as Madian, &c. H. --- The order of conquests is not observed, (M.) for while the commander-in-chief was in one place, his generals were dispersed into different parts. He had now advanced as far as Gabaa of Saul, (H.) when meditating a serious attack upon Egypt, he thought proper to concentrate his forces; little expecting to meet with such a check at Bethulia. C. --- Gr. "He came to Esdrelon, near Dotaia, (or Dothaim, north of Sichem) which is opposite the great saw of Judea," or the range of mountains of Ephraim. C. ---

Old Vulg.

"of Juda," dividing it from Idumea. The kings of Israel had fortified the defiles.

3 K. xv. 17.

Ver. 15. Took. Gr. "encamped between Gaba and Scythopolis, (Bethsan. Jos.

xvii. 11.) and he was there a month of days, to collect all the burden of his army."

JUDITH 4

CHAPTER IV.

Ver. 1. Juda, whither those had retreated who had escaped the fury of the Assyrians, under Theglathphalassar, &c. H.

Ver. 2. Temples. Surrendering would not secure these things; so that their very life and religion were at stake. Resistance, in other circumstances, would have been rashness. C. --- Gr. adds,

"because they were recently come up from captivity, and lately all the people had been collected out of Judea, and the vessels, and the altar, and the house, had been purified from profanation,"

(H.) to which they had been exposed under Manasses, (C. v. 23. C.) who with several of his subjects had been made prisoner, and was now at Babylon; or, if returned, (H.) was wholly taken up with the concerns of his soul, and committed the care of affairs to Eliachim. See Joseph. x. 4.

2 Par. xxxiii. 12. 16. C.

Ver. 3. Samaria, though an enemy's country, as the danger was common. M. ---

Ezechias and Josias seemed to claim a right over the country. 2 Par. xxx. 1. &c.

xxxiv. 6. and 33.

Ver. 4. War. Gr. adds, "as the harvest was just ended."

Ver. 5. Priest. Gr. "the great priest in Jerusalem, in those days, wrote to the inhabitants of Betouloua, (H. Bethulia, in the tribe of Simeon) and of Betemestham, (Bethsames. C.) which is over-against Esdrelon, and the plain near Dothaim, giving orders to seize the mountainous ascents, by which there was a passage into Judea; and it was easy to stop their progress, as the passage was narrow, and would not admit above two men at once." This reminds us of the heroic resistance which Leonidas, with his 300 Spartans, made to the millions in the army of Xerxes, at Thermopylæ. H. --- It seems that Jews attempted to defend these defiles. They had received the orders before the enemy encamped near Scythopolis.

Ver. 6. Them. Gr. adds, "and the senate of all the people of Israel, which sat at Jerusalem."

Serarius thinks that Manasses was busy fortifying the city, and had committed the rest of the kingdom to Eliachim, (M. W.) who received such high commendations. Isai. xxii. 20. C. --- But is more probable that he was at Babylon. Houbigant.

Ver. 7. Wives. Gr. adds, "and their little ones, and beasts, and every sojourner, and hired servant and slave. They put sackcloth on their loins, and every man, woman, and child, and the inhabitants of Jerusalem, fell prostrate before the temple, and sprinkled ashes on their heads."

The very beasts were covered with sackcloth, to denote the general sorrow. H.

Ver. 8. Priests. Gr. "and they spread their sackclothes before the Lord, and arrayed the altar with sackcloth." H. --- This spectacle must have made impression on the most obdurate. C.

Ver. 9. Off. Lit. "divided" from their husbands, (H.) or among the victors. M. ---

Gentiles. Gr.

adds, "and God heard their petition, and rescued them from their affliction; and all the people fasted many days in all Judea and Jerusalem, before the sanctuary of the Lord all mighty; and the high priest, Joachim, and all the priests who stood before the Lord, and ministered to the Lord, having their loins girded with sackcloth, offered the accustomed holocaust and the vows and presents of the people, and ashes were upon their caps, and they cried to the Lord with all their power, to look down graciously upon all the house of Jerusalem. And," C. v.

Ver. 10. Israel, before the approach of the enemy. H. v. 5.

Ver. 15. Clothes, conformably to the advice of Joel, i. 13. C.

JUDITH 5

CHAPTER V.

Ver. 1. Mountains. Gr. adds, "and had fortified every summit of a high mountain, and had placed scandals in the plains," obstructing the passage (H.) with ditches, trees, (C.) and snares of every description. H.

Ver. 2. Ammon. Gr. adds, "and the satraps of the maritime country," (H.) the Philistines, who had submitted like the rest.

Ver. 3. Them. Gr. adds, "Ye sons of Chanaan tell." He was not acquainted with their origin: the title belonged only to the Phœnicians, (C.) who might also be present. H.

Ver. 4. East. Gr. "west," which seems more accurate, unless Holofernes was on the sea-coast, (C.) or that part of the country went by this name, as it does at present. H. --- He was not absolutely unacquainted with the Jews, but spoke in contempt, (v. 27. W. M.) and wished to know if they had formed a league with the Egyptians, &c. C.

Ver. 5. My. Gr. "the mouth of thy slave." H.

Ver. 6. Chaldeans. Abraham was a native of Ur. Gen. xii. C. --- This tended to conciliate the favour of the general, who as of the same country. M.

Ver. 9. Heaven. Gr. adds, "the God whom they had known, and they (the Chaldean idolaters) cast them out from the face of the gods, and they fled into Mesopotamia, and dwelt there many days: (H. that is, about two years. C.) and their God commanded them to leave their abode, and to go into the land of Chanaan; and they dwelt there, and were enriched;...and when," &c. ---

There. Gr. "and where there till they returned; and there they became innumerable." H.

Ver. 10. Oppressed. Gr. "craftily inveigled them." Ex. i. 10.

Ver. 11. Plague. Gr. adds, "for which there was no remedy. And the Egyptians cast them out from among them. And God dried up the Red Sea before them, and conducted them to Mount Sinai and Cades-Barne, and cast out all the inhabitants of the desert; and they dwelt in the land of the Amorrhites, and exterminated all the Hesebon, by their power. Then crossing the Jordan, they took as their inheritance all the mountainous parts, and ejected the Chanaanite, Pherezite, Jebusite, Sichem, and all the Gergesites, and dwelt therein many days. And, " v. 21. H. --- The environs of Sichem belonged to the Hevites. C.

Ver. 14. Rested. This is attested, Deut. xxxii. 10. and Jer. ii. 6. M.

Ver. 16. Overcame, in the days of Josue, (M.) at Jericho, &c. H.

Ver. 22. Battles. He seems to speak of the captivity of Manasses, (W.) of the ten tribes, and of the loss sustained by Achaz. 2 Par. xxviii. 5. M. --- By many. Gr.

"exceedingly; and they were led captive into a land which was not their own, and the temple of their God became as a pavement, and their cities were taken by the enemies. But now, returning to their God, they are come up from the places to which they had been scattered, and have possession of Jerusalem, where is their sanctuary; and they have inhabited the mountainous country, for it was a desert."

H. --- Our adversaries would infer from this, and similar passages, that the siege of Bethulia could not have taken place till after the captivity of Babylon; and this many Catholics allow. But the proof is not conclusive, as all this might be verified under Manasses: (C.) "the temple was trampled on," (Syr.

egennethe eis edaphos) and profaned. See C. iv. 2. and 1 Mac. iii. 51. and Luke xxi. 24. It had been pillaged by Sesac and the Assyrians, and had stood in need of great repairs under Ezechias, Josias, &c. Several of the Israelites had escaped from the hands of their oppressors, (2 Par. xxxiv. 9.) and the Jews had regained their strength after the captivity of Manasses, (C.) having retired before into their strong holds in the deserts. H.

Ver. 25. Cannot. Gr. "let my lord indeed pass by, lest their Lord should cover them with a shield, for their God is for them, and we," &c.

Ver. 26. All the. Gr. "all the people round the tent murmured; and the great men of Holofernes, and all who dwelt in the maritime country, and in Moab, threatened to cut him to pieces. For we shall not fear the children of Israel. Lo!

a people without power, strength, or army in battle array!

We shall then go up, and they shall be for food to all thy army, lord Holofernes.

And," C. vi.

Ver. 27. Who. They speak thus through indignation, though they knew Achior well enough. W.

--- Their blasphemous presumption was soon punished. M.

Ver. 29. Other. This foolish attempt was not peculiar to this king. The great Nabuchodonosor was infected with the same vanity, (Dan. vi. 7.) and was imitated by many of the Persian monarchs, and by Alexander. Persas non piè tantum sed etiam prudenter Reges suos inter deos colere: Majestatem enim imperii salutis esse tutelam. Curtius viii. Yet most of the Greeks could not brook such flattery, though they were not influenced by religion, but by reason, and their own haughty temper. See Justin vi. Mart. x. 62.

JUDITH 6

CHAPTER VI.

Ver. 1. Achior. Gr. adds, "before all the populace of the strangers." And who art thou, Achior, before all this company of foreigners, and the sons of Moab? and what are the mercenaries of Ephraim, that thou? v. 2.

Ver. 2. To shew. Gr. "and who is God but Nabuchodonosor? He will," &c. H. ---

They allow the title to none but their king. Neither will God admit of any rival.

W. --- The generous advice of Achior was highly resented. Charidemus, who spoke with the like boldness to Darius, when Alexander approached, was even put to death, though the king repented when it was too late.

Curt. iii. Diod. xiv.

Ver. 6. People. Gr. "my slaves shall station thee on the mountainous country, and in one of the cities on the ascents, (of which thou hast so much spoken) and thou shalt not perish till thou perish with them. But if thou believest in thy heart that they will not be taken, let not thy countenance fall. I have spoken, and nothing that I have said shall be without effect."

Ver. 7. Bethulia. Travellers, depending on the uncertain traditions of the country, generally place this fortress in the tribe of Zebulon, about three miles west of Tiberias. See Brochard. &c. But S.

Jerom places it near Egypt; (Vita Hil.) and the Scripture speaks of Bethul, in the tribe of Simeon, (Jos. xix. 4.) to which Judith and the ancients belonged.

Holofernes left his camp near Scythopolis, (C. vii. 1.) when he proceeded (C.) to attack the southern countries. H.

Ver. 11. And. Gr. adds, "Chabris, the son of Othoniel, and Charmis, the son of Melchiel." M. ---

The former is, in effect, mentioned C. viii. 9. C.

Ver. 15. Pride. God will not fail to reward those who trust in him, (H.) and to humble the presumptuous. W. --- Saints. Syr. "sanctuary." This version and the Greek have only, "Look upon the face of the persons (or things) sanctified unto thee on this day. And they consoled Achior, and praised him greatly. And Ozias took him from the assembly to his own house, and made a feast (lit.

drinking) for the ancients, and they invoked the God of Israel to assist them during all that night." H.

Ver. 18. With us, observing the true religion. M.

Ver. 20. Over. The Jews eat nothing before night, and then no abstinence is prescribed, (C.) as the fast is at an end. H.

Ver. 21. The church. That is, the synagogue or place where they met in prayer.

Ch. --- For such places were established, particularly after the captivity, though some have denied that there were any synagogues, even in the days of the Machabees. See Mat. iv. 23. Est. iv. 16. C.

JUDITH 7

CHAPTER VII.

Ver. 2. Twenty. Gr. seventy; Syr. sixty-two. C. --- Two, &c. Gr. twelve, as above.

C. ii. 7. M.

--- Syr. twenty-two. Some of these texts must be inaccurate. C. --- Yet the cavalry of Holofernes (H.) might be increased, since he began the war. ---

Taken. Syr. "servants, and those who had joined them in great numbers."

Ver. 3. Hill side, on the coast of the Mediterranean, leaving the mountains of Ephraim, (C.) which were so strait, (H.) on the left, as well as Jerusalem, as he intended to go into Egypt.

Bethulia alone opposed his progress. C. vi. 7.

Ver. 4. Of them. Gr. adds, "were greatly afraid, and each one said to his neighbour: Now these will consume (Complut. shut up) the face of the earth, and neither the high mountains, nor the vales, nor the hills, will bear their weight. Then taking their arms, and lighting fires upon their towers, they kept guard all that night: but the second day, Holofernes brought out all his cavalry against the Israelites, in Bethulia, and he reconnoitred the ascent of thier city, and came to the fountains of their waters, and took them; and leaving a guard of soldiers, he returned to his men,"

&c. v. 8. H. --- The Syr. is also silent about the aqueduct and the small springs.

C. --- The servants of God first humble themselves, and then take arms, confiding in God. W.

Ver. 6. An aqueduct: the fountain must therefore have been on a higher ground than the city, though the latter was on an eminence. C. --- Yet water may be forced to ascend by pipes. H.

Ver. 8. Children of. Gr. and Syr. "the chiefs of the sons of Esau," as Idumea had been conquered. C. iii. 14. They omit Ammon, and after Moab subjoin "the generals of the maritime countries;" Tyrians and Philistines. H.

Ver. 10. Spring. Gr. and Syr. intimate that the Ammonites and Moabites, with 5,000 Assyrian infantry, guarded the springs: the rest of the army, according to the old Vulg. was stationed in the plain. Gr. and Syr. specify over-against Dothaim, which seems too remote; (C.) though such an immense army might cover a great part of the country, as all would not be necessary to besiege Bethulia; and it was agreed only to blockade the place, in order that no men might be lost, and the army might be ready to march against the more distant and powerful nations of Egypt. Another detachment was (H.) "southward, at Ecrebel, (Syr. Ekarbat, probably Akrabim, the ascent of the scorpions) near Cush, (or Arabia) which is above the torrent Mochmur, (Syr. Peor, or Bezor. C.) and the rest of the army of the Assyrians encamped in the plain, and covered the face of the earth." H.

Ver. 11. Days. Gr. "and all the collection of the Assyrians continued round them...thirty-four days." H. --- Old Vulg. "twenty-four days." Syr. "two months and four days." --- Measure. Gr.

adds, "the infants, women, and young men fainted, and fell down dead." H.

Ver. 13. Hands. We shall be treated as miserable slaves. C.

Ver. 15. Assemble. Gr. "call them, and give up all the city to plunder to the," &c.

Ver. 17. Conjuring. Gr. "and the sins of our parents, that he may not treat us thus to-day," and deliver us up to death. H.

Ver. 18. Saying. Gr. "And Ozias said to them: Take courage, brethren.," v. 23. H.

Ver. 23. Five. Sulpitius reads, fifteen. C. --- But instead of decim, we should read demum. H.

Ver. 25. Spoken. Gr. and Syr. add, "and he dispersed the people to their tents, and they went upon the walls and towers of the city, and sent their wives and children home. And they were under great humiliation in the city."

JUDITH 8

CHAPTER VIII.

Ver. 1. Idox. Gr. "ox," &c. All the versions disagree, as the copyists have probably taken in part of v. 3 too soon, supposing that the genealogy of women was never given. S. Fulgentius (ep. ad Gallam) differs from all, giving the ancestors of Manasses as the same with those of Judith. C. ---

Simeon, the son of Ruben. In the Greek it is, the son of Israel. For Simeon, the patriarch, from whom Judith descended, was not the son, but the brother of Ruben. It seems more probable, that the Simeon and the Ruben here mentioned are not the patriarchs, but two of the descendants of the patriarch Simeon: and that the genealogy of Judith, recorded in this place, is not carried up so high as the patriarchs. No more than that of Elcana, the father of Samuel, (1 K. i. 1.) and that of king Saul. 1 K. ix. 1. Ch. --- Others think that Judith descended from Ruben, by her father, and from Simeon, by her mother; (E.) or that, instead of son of Ruben, we should read "brother." But as we know that Judith calls Simeon her father, (C. ix. 2.) it is more likely that Ruben has been placed for Israel, as it is in Syr. S. Fulg. &c. This correction is maintained by Bellarmine, Salien, M. C. --- Thus both Judith and her husband were of the same tribe, the former by Salathiel, the latter by Sarisadai. C. --- Innumerable are the mistakes in the proper names, in Scripture. H. ---

Some of these might have had more than one. Gr. has Sarasdai, (Compl.

"Saladai;" Alex. Sept.

"Salasadai.") instead of Simeon, son of Israel: (C.) Alex. " Jeél, " which is probably a contraction for Israel. H.

Ver. 2. Who. Gr. adds, "of her tribe and family, and he died in the days," &c.

Ver. 3. Died. Gr. "fell upon his couch; (Grabe adds, "an died in Betuloua, his own city,") and they buried him with his fathers, in the field between Dothaim and Balamo." H. --- These places seem to be added without reason, as they were too remote from Bethulia. C.

Ver. 4-5. Six. So the old Vulg. Gr. and Syr. have, four months. --- Private. Gr. "a tent on the roof," that she might look towards Jerusalem, and pray with less distraction. Absalom lay in such a situation. 2 K. xvi. 22. C. --- In which. Gr.

"and she put sackcloth," &c. v. 6. H. --- It was a rough sort of garment. C. ---

Judith led a most religious life, in prayer, hair-cloth, and fasting, all the year, except on the festivals. W.

Ver. 6. Loins. Gr. "and she had on the garments of her widowhood, and." H. ---

She laid these aside. C. x. ii. C. --- Life. Gr. "widowhood, except the day before the sabbath, and the sabbaths, and the new moons, and feasts, and days of rejoicing of the house of Israel." H. --- Syr. and old Vulg. omit, "the day before the sabbath;" and perhaps it may not have been in the original, the Greek translator having inserted it conformably to the practice of his times. It was then prescribed to abstain from fasting, that the joy of the festival might not be impaired, (Grot.) and because it would be necessary to taste what was made ready for the sabbath; (Skikard, Purim) or rather because, as the festival began on Friday, between the two vespers, or from three to six in the afternoon, during the equinoxes, the fast could not be rigorously observed on Friday. C.

New moons were days of rejoicing. M. 1 K. xx. 5. --- The Jews kept two days together, for fear of missing the day on which the moon really appeared.

Several feasts were also prescribed perhaps before this time, on the 1st and 22nd of Nisan, &c.

Ver. 7. Of oxen. Gr. Syr. &c. add, "and fields, and she lived on them."

Ver. 8. Her. "The reputation of chastity in women is tender, and, like a beautiful flower, presently withers at the least blast, and perishes; particularly when they are at an age prone to vice, and destitute of the authority of a husband, whose shadow is the safeguard to a wife." S.

Jer. ad Salvinam. --- The Scripture could not give Judith a greater character. C.

--- How few can obtain it at present, though their virtue may be most pure, detraction is so keen! H.

Ver. 9. When. Gr. and Syr. "and she heard of the evil discourses of the populace against the magistrate, as they lost courage on account of the scarcity of water; and Judith heard of all the words of Ozias to them, how he had sworn to them that he would deliver up the city to the Assyrians after five days. Then sending her maid, whom she had placed at the head of all her possessions, she called Ozias," &c. The following verses give the same sense as the Vulg. though in other words, and with some additional circumstances.

H.

Ver. 13. Pleasure. She blames the magistrates for taking a rash oath, pretending to fathom the designs of God, and to fix a time for him, and not attempting to make any resistance, though the welfare of the whole nation, and the sacred things, depended on their exertions. C. --- They had been assured that God had heard their prayer, (C. iv. 9.) and had often witnessed a miraculous interference of Providence. In other circumstances (H.) the magistrates would not have been to blame, though Judith might think them so; (Serarius. See v. 26. M.) and, in effect, they ought rather to have died than thus to have exposed all to certain ruin. W.

Ver. 15. Man. Gr. "But do not you govern the designs of the Lord, our God, for God is not to be menaced like a man, nor forced to give an account like the son of man." H. Num. xxiii. 19.

Ver. 18. For. Gr. "As there has not arisen in our families generations, nor is there at this day either tribe, or family, or populace, or city among us, adoring gods made with hands, as it happened in days past;" in the former part of the reign of Manasses. All had begun to open their eyes, at the sight of the dreadful catastrophe. H.

Ver. 20. Let. Gr. "Wherefore we hope that he will not despise us, nor those of our race; nor, if we be taken, will Judea be so styled, our sacred things will be plundered. He will require his profanation at our mouth," &c. She shews the dread consequences which will ensue from the rash oath, and from such dastardly conduct under trial. H.

Ver. 21. Brethren. Gr. adds, "Let us shew our brethren that their soul depends on us, and the holy things, and the house, (temple) and the altar, are supported by us." These were not therefore demolished. C. v. 22. H. --- "Yea, let us give thanks, above all, to the Lord our God, who tries us like our fathers.

Remember," &c.

Ver. 23. Jacob. Gr. adds, "in Mesopotamia...because he does not take vengeance on us, as he made them pass through fire to examine their heart.

But the Lord, for an admonition, chastises those who approach to him. And Ozias," v. 28. H.

Ver. 25. Destroyer. As this word is not used elsewhere, (W.) S. Paul seems to allude to this passage, (1 Cor. x. 10.) as Judith does to various punishments (Num. xi. 1. and xiv. 12. and xx. 4.

C.) inflicted by an angel. M.

Ver. 26. Suffer, as if to shew our impatience (H.) and anger against God. M.

Ver. 28. Words. Gr. adds, "for it is not to-day only that thy wisdom has appeared, but from thy earliest days all the people has known thy prudence, as the formation (H. Syr. the thought. C.) of thy heart is good. But the people was much oppressed with thirst, and they forced us to...take an oath, which we shall not break. Now," &c. H. --- It hence appears that Judith was not very young; and as many desired to marry her, (C. ult. Gr.) we may conclude that she was of a middle age, or about thirty-five. Houbigant.

Ver. 29. God. Gr. adds, "and the Lord will send rain to fill our reservoirs, and we shall faint no longer. And Judith replied: Hear me, and I will perform an action which shall come to the ears of all future generations of our race. You," &c. v.

32. H. --- She did not tell what she was going to do. C.

Ver. 32. Servant. Gr. abra, commonly (H.) denotes a maid of honour, (W.) or companion, though sometimes it is applied to people of loose morals. This servant had probably the administration of the affairs of her mistress, v. 9. C.

--- Pray. Gr. "as you...the Lord will by my hand look," &c.

Ver. 33. And till. Gr. "for I shall not tell you, till what I am about be accomplished. And Ozias, with the princes, said to her."

Ver. 34. Departed. Gr. adds, "from the tent to their respective stations."

JUDITH 9

CHAPTER IX.

Ver. 1. Oratory. Of such our Saviour speaks, Matt. vi.; and Baronius at large.

A.D. 293. W. ---

Gr. "But Judith fell prostrate, and sprinkled ashes upon her head, (Syr. adds, and tore her tunic) and uncovered the sackcloth which she had on. That evening the incense had just been offered, in the house of the Lord, at Jerusalem. And Judith cried aloud," &c.

Ver. 2. Gavest him a sword, &c. The justice of God is here praised, in punishing by the sword of Simeon the crime of the Sichemites: and not the fact of Simeon, which was justly condemned by his father. Gen. xlix. 5. Though even with regard to this fact, we may distinguish between his zeal against the crime committed by the ravishers of his sister, which zeal may be considered just: and the manner of his punishing that crime, which was irregular and excessive. Ch. --- The former is here commended. W. M. --- Yet Simeon was not blameless. God put the sword into his hand as he makes use of tyrants; in which sense Nabuchodonosor is styled his servant. Jer. xxv.

9. Ezec. xxix. 18. Gen. xxiv. 2. 25.

Ver. 3. And. Gr. "For thou didst say: It shall not be so: and they did it because thou hadst given their princes unto slaughter, and their bed, which had perceived their deceit, unto blood; and thou didst slay the slaves with the princes, and the princes on their thrones; and thou gavest," &c. H.

--- This style seems rather poetical. Grot. C.

Ver. 4. Of old. Gr. "before these, and these, and what followed, and is at present, and things to come, thou hast foreseen." All events depend on Thee.

**"For the things which thou hadst decreed were at hand, and said:
Behold, we are here." H.**

**Ver. 5. Judgments. All is foreseen: nothing can resist the decrees of
God. C.**

**Ver. 6. As. Gr. speaks not of the Egyptians: "For behold the Assyrians
are multiplied in their power, and exalted on account of their cavalry;
they have boasted on the strong arm of the infantry, have trusted in
their shield, and bow, and sling; and they have not known that thou art
the Lord, making an end of wars: Thy name is Lord; break their force,
by thy power," &c. v. 11.**

H.

Ver. 7. Them, as they were not able to come to action during the night.
Ex. xiv.

Ver. 13. Lips, or with my endearing speeches. M. --- She meant innocently to engage the affections of Holofernes, (H.) and prays that he may receive her in that manner, as he might have done without sin. But when he abused his free-will, God turned his sin to the good of others. See Ex. vii. S. Aug. ser. 288. W.

--- Gr. "Give that power which I have devised to the hand of me, a widow. Strike the slave by the lips of my delusion, (or by my ensnaring words) with the prince; and the chief, with his minister, break their haughtiness by the hand of a female, v. 15. H. --- This prayer seems contrary to sound morality, as well as the indiscreet conduct of Judith, in exposing herself to danger, though her intention was good. C. --- But are not stratagems lawful in war?

See 2 K. xv. Is it sinful for a woman to endeavour to captivate the heart? The situation might be dangerous, but it was not criminal; and Judith was certainly determined to yield to no dishonest proposals. God therefore approved of her designs, and enhanced her beauty. C. x. 4. H.

Ver. 16. Horses. Gr. "the potent, but thou art the Lord of the humble."

Ver. 17. And. Gr. "give my word and deceit to be a wound and a scar to them, who, against thy covenant and sanctified house, and the summit of Sion,...have devised cruel things, and do for all thy nation according to thy power and strength; for there is no other to shield Israel but Thou."

JUDITH 10

CHAPTER X.

Ver. 2. House. Gr. adds, "where she spent the sabbath and festival days, she rolled up her," &c.

H. --- She remained in her oratory therefore only on other days. C.

Ver. 3. Body. Compl. Gr. "mouth." But other editions seem more accurate. H. ---

Best. Gr.

"thick," probably the myrobalanum of Pliny xii. 21. and xiii. 1. ---
Bonnet, or mitre, tied with ribbands, hanging down behind, like those
of bishops. ---

Sandals, highly ornamented, and worn by people of quality. C. ---
Lilies, pendent from the neck. Grot.

Ver. 4. And. Gr. "and she was richly adorned, so that she might
captivate (literally, deceive) the eyes of whatever men should behold
her. And," v. 5. H. ---

The fathers highly extol her virtue, and shew was, no doubt, actuated
by the purest motives. Yet she might be guilty of some indiscretion.
Even the working of miracles would not prove the contrary, as wicked
priests may confer the sacraments; and Moses was reprehensible the
moment (C.) before (H.) he wrought a miracle. Num. xx. 10. Mat. vii.
22. God inspired her with the laudable design of freeing her country,
but the means were left to her own choice. C. ---

The making use of this rich attire was not, however, sinful in itself; and
we have no right to suspect that Judith gave any way either to vanity or
to sensuality. How many ladies of quality are dressed so as to enchant
all those who are not upon their guard! Yet, provided they observe due
modesty, who will blame their rich attire or perfumes? H. --- Judith
might lawfully desire to marry Holofernes for the good of her nation,
(M.) as Esther became the wife of Assuerus, though an infidel. The
general seemed even willing to become a convert. C. xi. 21. H.

Ver. 5. Bottle; made of leather, (C.) used for carrying wine. Pollox. M. --
- Corn. It was eaten either steeped in water or mixed with oil. ---
Cheese. So the Syr.

reads. Gr. "pure loaves." C. ---

Why she took her provisions with her, she explains. C. xii. 2. M.

Ver. 7. Her. Gr. adds, "with her countenance and robes changed."

Ver. 8. But. Gr. "And they said to her, May God, the God of." --- With. Gr. "For the glory of the Israelites, and the exaltation of Jerusalem; and they adored God. And she said to them, Order the gate of the city to be opened for me, and I will go out to accomplish what you were talking about to me. And they commanded the young men to open for her; and they did so. But Judith and her maid went out. And the citizens looked at her while she descended the hill, till she had passed the valley, when they lost sight of her; and they passed along straight through the vale, and the advanced guard of," &c. H. --- It appears that there was still day-light, (C.) or the moon shone brightly. H.

Ver. 12. Because I knew, &c. In this and the following chapter, some things are related to have been said by Judith, which seem hard to reconcile with truth.

But all that is related in Scripture of the servants of God, is not approved by the Scripture: and even the saints in their enterprizes may sometimes slip into venial sins. Ch. --- By means of mental reservation, we may exculpate her from lying. Serar. M. --- But this expedient is bad and childish. H. --- She might speak ironically, (Carthus.) or prophetically. Raban. Glossa, &c. --- Still it might be an untruth, (C.) to be excused, like stratagems in war. M. --- How often does an enemy give out that he is going to march to some place, when he intends to go quite another way! H. --- I knew. Gr. "Because they are about to be given up a prey to you. Therefore, I come to Holofernes, general in chief of your army, to inform him of the truth, and to shew," &c. H. --- She spoke many things certainly true, and others which would probably have taken place, if God had not sent relief. W.

Ver. 15. Lord. Gr. adds, "and now proceed to his tent, and some of us shall give thee into his hands. But if thou stand before him, let not thy heart fear, but tell him this, and he will treat thee well. And they selected 100 men, and surrounded her and her servant-maid, and conducted her to the tent of Holofernes. And they ran from all parts of

the camp, as soon as her coming was made known, and they came round her as she stood without the tent of Holofernes, till they had told him of her. And they were astonished at her beauty, and at the Israelites, and said to each other, Who," &c. v. 18.

Ver. 18. That we. Gr. "For it is not expedient to leave one man of them alive, lest they should delude all the earth." (Old Vulg. omits the negation.) "And all who slept near Holofernes, and all his servants, came out and introduced her into the tent;" (H. which was divided into two apartments. Heraclides) "and Holofernes was reposing on a bed in the canopy, (or inner room) which," &c.

H. --- The curtain was intended to keep off gnats. M. Anthony imitated this delicacy.

Interque signa (turpe!) militaria,

Sol aspicit conopæum. Hor. epod. ix. C.

Ver. 20. After. Gr. "And they told him of her, and he came out to the forepart of the tent, and silver lamps preceded him, (H.) either for grandeur, as they did the kings of Persia and the emperors of Rome and of the Turks, or because it was still dark." C. --- "But as soon as Judith came in sight of him and of his ministers, they all were astonished at the beauty of her face; and falling prostrate, she adored him, (with civil respect) and his servants lifted her up."

H. --- S.

Fulgentius (ep. 2.) judges, with great probability, that Judith was now about 40

years old. W.

JUDITH 11

CHAPTER XI.

Ver. 1. King. Gr. adds, "of all the earth."

Ver. 3. Why. Gr. "And art come to us? For thou art come for thy own safety."

Take courage, for thou shalt live this night and henceforth, as no one shall hurt thee, but shall do thee good, as the servants of my lord, Nabuchodonosor, the king, are treated."

Ver. 4. Handmaid. Gr. adds, "and I will tell no untruth to my lord this night, for,"

&c. --- Thing.

Gr. adds, "and none of the projects of my lord shall fail." H. --- All that Judith said was true in her sense, though the enemy did not understand her properly.

So Josue lawfully entrapped the citizens of Hai. S. Aug. q. 10. in Jos. viii. W.

Ver. 5. Liveth. She imitates Joseph, (Gen. xlii. 15.) and Eliseus; (4 K. ii. 4.) and speaks the truth, as the general had subjected many to his master. M. --- Her speech was not superstitious, but shewed a civil respect. C.

Ver. 7. To him. Gr. intimates that she advised him to follow his counsel. "For our nation is not punished with the sword, unless they sin against their God.

But now let not my lord be at a loss what to do. For death has fallen upon them, and sin has taken possession of them, so that they have irritated God by their folly," &c. v. 10. This might also be true, though they had not fallen into idolatry (C. viii. 18. H.) at Bethulia. M.

Ver. 8. Prophets. Though this had been threatened by the ancient prophets, (H.) we cannot pretend to specify which she means. C.

Ver. 10. Famine. They might have provisions, but they would be useless, on account of excessive thirst. M.

Ver. 11. Drink. Gr. "and all that God had forbidden them to eat by his laws, (H.) without making any distinction between the clean and unclean. Grot. --- Blood was prohibited even before the law. Gen. ix. 4. Lev. xvii. 14. C.

Ver. 12. Oil. Gr. may explain this. "And the first-fruits of corn, and the tithes of wine and of oil, which they had reserved as sacred for the priests, standing in Jerusalem, before our God, they had decreed to consume; though none of the people ought so much as to touch these things. Yet they have sent to obtain permission of the senate at Jerusalem, where the people have done the like.

And when they shall have obtained an answer, they will fall to work, and then they will be abandoned to be destroyed by thee." H. --- She insinuates that her countrymen are in the utmost distress, and not much attached to religion; (C.) though in extreme want the distinction of meats is not to be enforced. H.

Ver. 13. Tell. Gr. "To perform with thee a feat which will astonish all who shall hear of these things. For thy handmaid is religious, and serveth the God of heaven day and night; and now my lord, I am," &c.

Ver. 14. God. Gr. adds, "in the night, in the valley."

Ver. 15. He will. Gr. "They shall have completed their sins." --- Tell thee. Gr.

adds, "and thou shalt go out with all thy forces, and none of them shall resist thee; and I will bring thee through Judea, over-against Jerusalem, and will place thy throne in the midst of it, and thou shalt drive them like sheep," &c. ---

Dog. This is proverbial. Ex. xi. 7. C. --- All Israel was at rest after the death of Holofernes. Judith brought his head in triumph through the country. The promise of dominion (H.) was ironical. 3 K. xxii. 15. M.

**Ver. 16. God. Gr. "My foreknowledge; and I was sent to inform thee."
H. --- She flatters Holofernes with the idea that he is under the special care of heaven. C.**

Ver. 20. That. Gr. "To increase our strength, and to bring destruction on those who have despised my lord."

Ver. 21. Because. Gr. "And now thou art comely in thy appearance, and good in thy discourse.

If then thou perform what thou hast spoken, thy God shall," &c. H. --- It is hardly probable that he spoke in earnest. Perhaps he did not know that the true God allowed of no other. Being captivated with Judith's beauty, and perceiving that she was attached to religion, he had a mind to remove all her objections to his person. C.

JUDITH 12

CHAPTER XII.

Ver. 1. And bade. Gr. "and ordered a bed (or table) to be prepared for her, to eat of his own meat, and drink of his wine," (H.) that her beauty might be enhanced, (Dan. i.) and to honour her. M.

Ver. 2. Upon me, as these meats had been offered to idols; (W.) or she might fear they had, and wished to avoid all scandal. 2 Mac. vi. 21. Tob. i. 12. C.

Ver. 3. Thee. Gr. adds, "for there is none of thy race."

Ver. 4. Which I. Gr. "he." --- Which. Gr. "and she slept till midnight and she arose at the morning watch." H. --- The mode of counting by hours prevailed after the captivity. C.

Ver. 5. And. Gr. "and she sent to Holofernes, saying: May my lord please to order that thy handmaid may go out to pray. And," &c. v. 6. H. --- She had prepared him to grant this request before: but out of civility, and that he may have greater confidence in her, she asks again. The choice of a retired place for prayer is very commendable, but she made choice of the fields, that she might go out of the camp afterwards without being suspected. C.

Ver. 6. Chamberlains. Gr. "life-guards, not to hinder her; and she remained in the camp three days." H.

Ver. 7. Water. Gr. "in the camp;" perhaps she washed only her hands and face.

C.

Ver. 9. Pure, from forbidden food. W. --- Evening. Thus she continued to fast, to draw down the blessing of God. C.

Ver. 10. Servants. Gr. adds, "only, and he did not call any of those whom he usually employed,"

(H.) that they might not witness his excesses. Vagao, or Bagoas, the Persian name for an

"eunuch," or chief officer; though such were generally to wait on the ladies.

Quem penes est Dominam servandi cura Bagoæ. Ovid, Amor. ii.

--- Eunuch. Gr. and Syr. add, "who was appointed over all his affairs. Persuade the Hebrew woman who is with thee to come to us, and to eat and drink with us. For we deem it shameful to dismiss such a woman, without having commerce with her; and if we do not attract her, she will deride us."

Ver. 12. Merry. This would pave the way for greater liberties. C. --- Gr. adds,

"and to become this day as a daughter of the Assyrians, standing to wait in the house of Nabuchodonosor." He probably alludes to those courtezans (C.) who sung at night, before the palace, &c. Athen. Dip.

xii. 2. The Persians admitted women to their feasts, though they were generally excluded in the East. Est. i. 12. Herod. v. 18.

Ver. 14. Best. Gr. "a boast, or matter of exultation." H. --- This answer seems to shock our delicacy. Did she not understand the meaning of the eunuch, which was sufficiently plain? She only passed a compliment, which always implies a tacit condition, if the thing be practicable and

honest: as the words might have two meanings, she was bound in charity to interpret them in the best sense. C.

--- It was surely lawful to be merry. M.

Ver. 15. Garments. Gr. adds, "and all her female ornaments; and her servant came and spread on the ground, before Holofernes, the fleeces which she had received from Bagoas, for her daily use, to eat lying upon them. And coming in, Judith fell prostrate." H. --- The custom of sitting on the ground, upon skins, to eat, is very ancient, (Targum, Est. i.) and is still observed by the Turks.

**The kings of Persia let none eat with them at the same table.
Heraclides. Athen.**

v. 10. --- The character of drunkenness, with which this nation has been branded, seems not unfounded. C.

Ver. 16. Her. Gr. adds, "company; and he had sought an opportunity of deluding her, from the day when he first beheld her." He justly, therefore, fell into the snare which he had laid.

Ver. 20. Life. Gr. adds, "in any one day," (H.) at supper. M.

JUDITH 13

CHAPTER XIII.

Ver. 1. Doors. Gr. adds, "without," yet so that Judith could open them. C.

Ver. 4. Drunk. Gr. "drowned in wine."

Ver. 5. The. Gr. "her chamber." --- Watch. Gr. adds, "her coming out, as on other days; for she had said she would go out to pray, and she had told this to Bagoas. And all had departed," &c.

All these precautions were necessary. H.

Ver. 6. Judith. She seems not to have disclosed her secret even to her companion, taking the whole upon herself. --- Lips. Gr. "in her heart." C. --- Yet the Jews generally use some words, (H.) thinking that prayer too cold, which is barely mental. Grotius.

Ver. 7. Raise up. If Bethulia had been taken, perhaps (H.) Jerusalem had also fallen. W.

Ver. 8. Pillar. Gr. κῆρυξ, "the rule," (C.) or pole on which the arms were hung.

Hesychius. ---

Sword, (acinace) used by the Persians, (M.) and shorter than the Greek or Roman sword. C. --- If she had not been inspired by God to act thus, like Aod, (Judg. iii.) it would be difficult to excuse her, in thus hurrying a many, in the most wretched state, before the judgment-seat of God. H.

Ver. 10. Canopy, to convince all that it was the head of Holofernes. M. -- - Body, on the ground; (C. xiv. 14.) perhaps to cut off the head more easily, (C.) and that it might appear more ghastly H.

at the first entrance. T.

Ver. 11. While, having composed herself, (H.) and done every thing necessary to prevent detection. M.

Ver. 13. Open. Gr. repeats, "open ye now the gate; God, our God is with us, still to shew power in Israel, and strength against the enemies, as he hath done to-day." H.

Ver. 14. That. Gr. "they hastened to descend to the gate of their city, and called," &c.

Ver. 15. Had now. Gr. "it was a paradox to them that she should come, and they opened the gate, and received them."

Ver. 16. And she. Gr. "said to them with a loud voice: Praise God, praise, yea praise God, because he hath not withdrawn his mercy from the house of Israel, but hath destroyed our enemies by my hand this night." H.

Ver. 19. Drunkenness. "The fasting of one woman overthrew an innumerable host of drunkards.

S. Amb. de jej. ix. W.

Ver. 20. And abiding. Gr. "for my face has deluded him to his ruin, and he has not committed sin with me, for defilement and shame. And all the people were much amazed; and bowing down, they adored the Lord, and said, with one accord: Our God, thou art blessed, because this day thou hast brought the enemies of thy people to nought." H. --- Judith's guardian angel defended her; as Jacob's did him. Gen. xlviii. W.

Ver. 23. Prince, in that town, though Manasses was king. M. --- Gr. "Ozias said."

Ver. 25. Praise. Gr. "hope." --- For that. Gr. "and may God make these things turn to thy eternal exaltation, to regard thee for good; because thou hast not."

--- Ruin. Gr. adds, "walking aright in,"

&c. H.

Ver. 27. And. This is related after v. 5, in the following chapter, in Gr. Syr. and the old Vulg. (C.) and indeed it seems to be there in its proper place. --- Head, or general. H.

Ver. 29. Fear. Astonished (M.) at the instability of human things, and admiring how God had rescued him from the threatened danger.

Ver. 30. Reverenced. Lit. "adored;" a word often used in this sense. H.

JUDITH 14

CHAPTER XIV.

Ver. 1. Walls. Gr. adds, "upon the pinnacle." H.

Ver. 2. Beneath. Into the valley; but make your appearance just out of the walls, as if you were rushing upon the enemy. Gr. adds after arms, "and you shall appoint a leader over them, as if descending into the plain to the advanced guard of the Assyrians; but ye shall not go down. Then these seizing all their armour, will go to the camp, and awaken the leaders of the Assyrians, and they will run to the tent of Holofernes, and shall not find him. Then fear shall seize upon them, and they will flee before us. Whereupon ye, and all who inhabit the confines of Israel, shall follow after, and strew them in their paths," slain and wounded, v. 6. H.

Ver. 6. Then. Gr. &c. "But before ye do this, call to me Achior, the Ammonite, that seeing, he may recognize the contemner of the house of Israel, and the man who sent him away to us unto certain death. And they called Achior from the house of Ozias. But as soon as he came, and saw the head of Holofernes in the hand of one of the assembly of the people, he fell," &c. as C. xiii.

29, 30. "Blessed art thou in every tent of Juda, and in every nation. All who shall hear thy name shall be amazed. But now tell me what thou hast done during these days. And Judith, in the midst of the people, informed him of all that she had performed, since the day of her departure till the time when she was speaking. She had no sooner ended her speech, than all the people set up a loud shout of joy in their city. Then," &c. --- Leaving. Gr. "He believed in God greatly, or with the utmost sincerity. H. --- Hitherto Achior had only considered the Deity as the peculiar God of Israel, (C.) or as the common gods "revered by all nations;" (Virg. xii. Servius) but not as the only supreme Being. He now becomes a proselyte, not merely, like Naaman, to adore one God; but also to observe all the rites of the Jewish religion. The latter was a matter of choice. C.

vi.

18. It is not still clear that he could enjoy the privileges of the nation as a magistrate, or even marry, (C.) which shews his greater fervour. Grotius. --- It is certain that no nation could be forbidden to worship God. Deut. xxiii. 3. S.

Thomas (1. 2. q. 105. a. 3.) believes that a dispensation was granted to Achior, (C.) so that he might be treated like an Israelite in all respects. Serar. q. 1. M. ---

The evinces that only the impenitent Ammonites, &c. were excluded from the Church. W. --- With. Gr. "till this day."

Ver. 7. With. Gr. "In companies, to the ascent of the mountain."

Ver. 8. Ran. Gr. "Sent to their officers. But they went to the leaders and captains of thousands, and to every chief among them, and they proceeded to the tent of Holofernes, and said to his chief steward: Awaken now our lord, for the slaves have been so bold as to come down to offer us battle for their utter ruin. The Bagoas," &c. v. 13. H.

Ver. 12. Mice. They speak contemptuously of their foes, like the Philistines. 1

K. xiv. 11. M.

Ver. 13. Into. Gr. "In, knocked at the hall, (aule, or antichamber) of the tent, for he suspected that he was sleeping with Judith. But as no one answered, he opened and went into the bed-chamber, and found him thrown upon the floor, dead, and his head taken from him, and he cried,"

&c. --- Curtain, which separated this apartment from the rest, (H.) and hung before the door, as Heraclides describes the tent of the Persian kings.

Holofernes assumed the like importance, and was treated almost as a deity. C.

--- Hence he must not be awaked, in a rude manner. H. ---

Civility requires that we should knock modestly at the doors of the great. C.

Ver. 16. Said. Gr. "cried aloud, the slaves have prevaricated. One," &c. H. ---

Perhaps he thought that Judith had introduced some of the Jews. C.

Ver. 18. Cry. Gr. adds, "and shouting of them (the captains) in," &c. H.

JUDITH 15

CHAPTER XV.

Ver. 1. All. Gr. "Those who were in the tents heard, they were astonished at the fact; and fear and trembling fell upon them, and there was not a man remaining before his neighbour; but rushing out, with one accord, they fled through every path, in the plains and in the mountains; and those who were encamped in the high places around Bethulia, (H. the Moabites, &c. C. vii. 8. C.) fled. Then every warrior of Israel rushed out upon them, and Ozias," v. 5.

Ver. 5. Israel. Gr. adds, "informing them of what had been accomplished, and that all might pour upon the enemies, to cut them off. But when the Israelites heard this, they all, unanimously, fell upon them, as far as Chobai: (H. Hoba.

C.) in like manner those from Jerusalem came up, and from all the mountainous country; for they also were informed of what had happened in the camp of their enemies; and the men of Galaad and of Galilee scattered them with great slaughter, till they had passed Damascus and its boundaries."

H. --- As the enemy fled without a leader, we may easily imagine what carnage would ensue. C.

Ver. 7. The. Gr. "their spoils, and were greatly enriched." H. --- Mariana suggests that we should read honestati, which is used in this sense, (Eccli. xi.

23.) instead of onustati, loaded.

Ver. 8. They. Gr. "The Israelites, returning from the slaughter, took possession of the remainder, and the villages and cities, both in the mountains and champaign country, took many spoils; for there was great abundance. But Joachim," &c.

Ver. 9. Came. Gr. adds, "and the senate of Israel, residing at Jerusalem, came."

This alludes to the sanhedrim. Grotius. --- But, it seems, its institution was posterior to the captivity, and we may understand the principal men of the city, or of the priests. C. --- To see. Gr. adds, "the good things (Compl. to confirm or lay a foundation for, the good things) which God had done to Israel, and to see Judith, and speak peace with her." Prot. "to salute her." H. --- Joachim is the same with Eliacim; El being only prefixed. T. --- He is the Sadoc II. or Odeas of Josephus; (Reinec.) and succeeded Sobna both in spiritual and temporal power. Isai. xxii. Bellarmin.

Ver. 10. She. Gr. "They were gone into her apartment, they," &c. --- Art the. Gr.

adds, "great joy, and the great boast of our race; because thou hast done all these things with thy hand, thou hast procured the good of Israel, and God hath been pleased with them. Be thou blessed by the omnipotent Lord for ever." H. --- Judith was a figure of the blessed Virgin, to whom these praises chiefly belong. Fulbert. W.

Ver. 11. Chastity, &c. This is not in Syr. &c. and though, generally speaking, celibacy was not esteemed honourable among the Jews, yet chastity was so much the more admired, as it was more uncommon. A widow was deserving of praise for not lightly entering upon a second marriage.

C. --- Those who abstain from it, were respected, like virgins, by the Romans.

Val. Maxim. ii. 1.

Ver. 13. Thirty. Gr. "And the people plundered the camp thirty (Syr. three) days." The camp of the Assyrians was in various places, and the people waited a month before they began to divide the spoils among all, according to their laws. Num. xxxi. 27. and 1 K. xxx. 24. C.

Ver. 14. But. Gr. "And they gave to Judith the tent of Holofernes, and all the silver plate, and beds and basins, and all his furniture, which she taking, place upon her mule, and put to her chariots, and heaped them thereon; and every woman of Israel ran to see her, and they blessed her, and danced in her honour. Then she took some thyrsus (H. or branches entwined with ivy,

&c. C.) in her hands, and gave to those women who accompanied her; and they crowned with olive both her and her attendant; (maid, or Alex. Sept. "and she was crowned with olive, and her mule;" Grabe substitutes "female companions,") and she went before all the people, leading the dance of all the women; and every man of Israel followed in arms, with crowns, and with hymns in their mouth. Then," &c. C. xvi. H. --- The bearing of green branches, on such occasions, was very common. Lev. xxiii. 40. 2 Mac. x. 7. Mat. xxi. 8.

Hence Tacitus (Hist. v.) supposed that the Jews adored Bacchus. But there was nothing here of the immodesty, which generally attended the pagan festivals. We only find this instance of women being crowned with olive. But this tree was very proper, as it was used in rejoicings: Ramo felicis olivæ; (Virg. vi.) on which Servius remarks, olivæ, arboris festæ. At certain races in Greece, women who gained the victory, were thus crowned; (Alex. Genial v. 8.) and it was used by the Roman cavalry on the ides of July, and in ovations.

Pliny xv. 4. --- The processions of the Church often admit of similar ornaments in honour of God, (T.) and to promote piety. H.

CHAPTER XVI.

Ver. 1. Sung. Gr. "Gave out this confession, in all Israel: and all the people echoed this praise;"

(H.) either repeating the whole after her, or singing the first verse as a chorus.

Ex. xv. 20. 1 K.

xviii. 6. 1 Par. xvi. 8. C. --- Saying. Gr. "And Judith said: Begin ye to my Lord."

H. --- It is time for us to break silence, and to sound forth the praises of God. C.

Ver. 3. Wars, or destroying armies. H. --- God is often represented as a mighty warrior. Isai. i.

24. Jer. ii. 20. Rom. ix. 29. C. --- This passage is quoted by S. Ephrem (ser. de 2.

Adv.) as a part of Scripture. W. --- Lord is. Gr. "For he has drawn me from the hands of my persecutors, into his camp, in the midst of the people." H.

Ver. 5. Mountains of Cilicia, and through the defiles of Libanus and Hermon, on the north of Palestine, by which road they were forced to come. The desert Arabia was impassable for a large army. C. --- North, including to the east. H.

Isai. xiv. 13. Jer. i. 13. Ezec. i. 4. --- Torrents, drinking them up, as Sennacherib boasted; (4 K. xix. 24.) and the Greek assert the same of the army of Xerxes.

Herod. vii. 108.

Epotaque flumina Medo

Prandente. Juv x.

The Gr. seems to insinuate that the Assyrians "stopped up the springs," to distress the country, as Philopator did. C. --- Valleys. Gr. "hills."

Ver. 6. To make. Gr. "that he would throw my children at the breast, on the pavement, and make," &c. H.

Ver. 7. Stuck. Lit. "hurt him, overturning all his projects, (C.) as the Greek (ηθετησεν) intimates. M. --- Him. Gr. "them, by the hand of a woman: For," &c.

Ver. 8. Men; soldiers. C. xiv. 6. Gen. xiv. 24. --- Titan. So the Sept. renders Raphaim. 2 K. v.

18. The Greek translator of this work seems to have read the poets, who pretend that the Titans attempted to take heaven by storm. C. --- Neither such giants as those who lived before the flood, (Gen. vi.) nor such as were seen after, (Num. xiii. W.) attacked Holofernes. H. --- Neither does the Vulgate give any authority to poetic fictions, but only adopts terms which are best understood.

T. S. Jer. in Amos v. 8.

Ver. 9. And put. Gr. "for the exaltation of those who laboured in Israel."

Ver. 10. Crown. Gr. "mitre," or ribband, ornamented with jewels. C. x. 3. Syr.

"net-work." ---

New. Gr. "linen stole," which was a long robe, usually of linen, and worn both by men and women. C. --- Deceived him; as he would make love to her, and thus give her an opportunity to perform what she had

designed. H. --- She was not actuated by the desire of being admired, but sought to deliver her people, v. 9. M.

Ver. 11. Sandals. The bandages which tied the shoe-soles (H.) to the feet, were most ornamental.

Isai. iii. The city of Antylla was assigned to furnish sandals for the queens of Egypt. Herod. xii.

98. C. --- With. Gr. "a sword (acinace) passed through his neck."

Ver. 12. Medes. This is the first mention of these two nations, who afterwards became so famous. Nabuchodonosor had overcome Phraortes. C. i. C.

Ver. 13. Then. Gr. "Than my lowly ones (H. she speaks thus contemptuously of the Assyrians.

C.) howled, my weak ones cried out through fear; they raised their voice, and were overthrown."

H. --- Others think that she is speaking of her fellow-citizens, (T.) or both. H.

Ver. 14. Damsels; young boys. Syr. "they run them through, as if they had been damsels." ---

Children, or "slaves." Syr. Being this overtaken, what could they do but sue for pardon? C. ---

Before. Gr. "of the Lord," &c.

Ver. 15. Let. Gr. "I will sing a new hymn to the Lord. Lord, thou art great." H.

Ver. 17. Spirit, and they. Gr. "he built" the world. Gen. i. 8. Ps. xxxii. 9. C.

Ver. 18. Waters, by earthquakes and storms. Job ix. 5. Isai. v. 25. Ps. xvii. 8.

Ver. 19. Great. Gr. "treated mercifully by thee: for little with thee is all sacrifice, for the odour of sweetness; and all fat is but the least for thy holocausts. But he who fears the Lord, is ever great." H. --- This text is remarkable, as it shews (C.) that no sacrifice can please God, without interior holiness. Outward magnificence will be otherwise rejected with contempt. W.

Ver. 20. He will visit them, is not in Greek, and only expresses the same again.

H.

Ver. 21. Flesh, which is thus punished for ever, (S. Aug. de Civ. Dei xxv. 4.) while the soul is still more tormented with the loss of God's vision.

W. --- The bodies of those who persecute God's people, will not only be thrown out with ignominy, but the impenitent shall suffer eternal torments. These worms and fires do not cease. They are not merely figurative, but real, according to the Fathers. Serar. q. 1. T. Essais de Mor. --- Though the damned have not yet their bodies, they are no less affected with pain; as people who have lost a member, often seem to feel pain in it. That our soul should even now suffer, when the body is hurt, depends on God's appointment. The Jews spoke of eternal torments in similar terms. Eccli. vii. 19. Isai. lxvi. 24.

Mar. ix. 45.

Ver. 22. And. Gr. "But as soon as they arrived at Jerusalem, they adored God; and when the people were purified, they offered their holocausts, and free gifts, and presents." H. --- They stood in need of purification, as they had shed blood, and had touched so many things of the Assyrians, which were to them unclean. C. Num. xxxi. 24.

Ver. 23. An anathema of oblivion. That is, a gift or offering made to God, by way of an everlasting monument, to prevent the oblivion or the forgetting of so great a benefit. Ch. --- Yet some would read (C.) oblationis, instead of oblivionis. T. --- Gr. and Syr. say nothing of oblivion.

The Scriptures, and pagan histories, are full of such monuments of gratitude, to perpetuate the memory of benefits received from above. C. --- Gr. "to the Lord, all the vessels," or furniture. C.

xv. 14. H. --- Joseph called one of his sons, Manasses, because God had caused him to forget his former toils. Gen. xli. 51. M. --- Judith's husband had the same name; and this victory made her forget past sorrow. H.

Ver. 24. Three. Syr. "one entire month." C. --- Joy. Gr. "and Judith remained with them."

Ver. 25. Was made. Gr. "returned also to Bethulia, and dwelt on her own possessions; and in her time, was honourable throughout all the land."

Ver. 26. Chastity. Gr. "many desired to have her, (H. in marriage. W.) but no man knew her,"

&c. H. --- She again practised the same mortifications which she had done before. Suidas. C. ---

Husband. Gr. adds, "when he was removed to his people. And proceeding, (to the temple, or advancing in age) she was very great, and she grew old in her,"

&c. H. --- She probably went up to Jerusalem at the great festivals. M.

Ver. 28. Five. Suidas alone reads, "fifty." Some would suppose that Judith lived 105 years after her husband's death; so that she might have been in all 125

years old. But she would thus have survived the siege of Jerusalem under Nabuchodonosor; (C.) and the text does not require this sense. H. --- See Ex.

xii. 40. T. --- Free; as she had been her assistant in such a glorious work.

M. --- Died. Gr. adds, "in Bethulia; and they buried her in the cave of her husband, Manasses."

See C. viii. 3.

Ver. 29. Seven days. The usual term; (Eccli. xxii. 13.) but it was extraordinary for the whole province (C.) to mourn for an individual. Gr. and Syr. add, "And she divided all her possessions, before her death, among the nearest relations of her husband, Manasses, and among her own,"

(H.) which was very equitable, as she had no children, (C.) we may suppose. T.

H.

Ver. 30. Years. Gr. "days." See the pref. H. --- Judith was a widow near seventy years, shewing an excellent pattern to all in that state.

Notwithstanding the many inducements which she might have had to marry again, she chose to abstain, for greater perfection. Mat. xix. and 1 Cor. vii. W.

--- From the death of Holofernes (A. 3348) to that of Josias, (A. 3394) only forty-six years of peace would occur in Juda. Hence Hardouin would suppose that the text speaks of the kingdom of Israel. But it would be hard to prove that it existed at that time, after the ten tribes had been led away. A. 3283. As the Scripture does not specify how old Judith was when she addressed Holofernes, (C.) she might be sixty-five. Vitre. --- If, therefore, we should make this peace last till the coming of Nabuchodonosor, to attack Jerusalem, about forty-six years might elapse before the period here assigned. C. --- It is, however, much more probable, (H.) that the peace subsisted from the 11th of Manasses to the death of Josias, 73 (Gr. 78) years; (T.) and that she was not above forty when she performed her exploit; as she was then styled a beautiful girl, (C. xii. 12.) and many desired to marry her. H. --- No instance can be produced, of the Jews entering into such contracts with those who were past child-bearing. Freret, who seems afraid to allow this book the same authority as the additions to Daniel, though both are equally rejected by Protestants, supposes that Bethulia was besieged in the 11th or 12th year of Josias; and, of course, that Judith would then be about eighty-four years old! Houbigant.

Ver. 31. But. This is taken from the Chaldee of S. Jerom, though omitted in the old Vulg. as well as in the Gr. and Syr. We find no express mention of this festival in the Jews' Calendar, (C.) though no one can doubt but it once was kept. D. --- It probably ceased during the captivity; as that, in memory of the victory over Nicanor, (which was kept in the days of Josephus, xii. 16.) has been long since abolished, (C.) with many others. D. --- Many suppose (C.) that the feast of Judith

concurrent with that of the new fire, when the temple was renewed under Judas the Machabee, on the 25th of Casleu, (Salien, &c.) in December, though the victory of Judith was obtained about August. The point is not easily decided. As the festival was of human institution, it might be abrogated by the same authority. C. --- In Judith we behold a widow indeed, such as the apostle commends. 1 Tim. v. 3. (S. Jer. ad Furiam. --- We may also raise our minds still higher, and contemplate in her a glorious figure of the Christian Church, which is spotless; and by the practice of all virtues, overcomes the power of persecutors, giving all the glory to God. After victory, she continues in silence to practise her former austerities, which render her secure in peace and terrible in war. C.